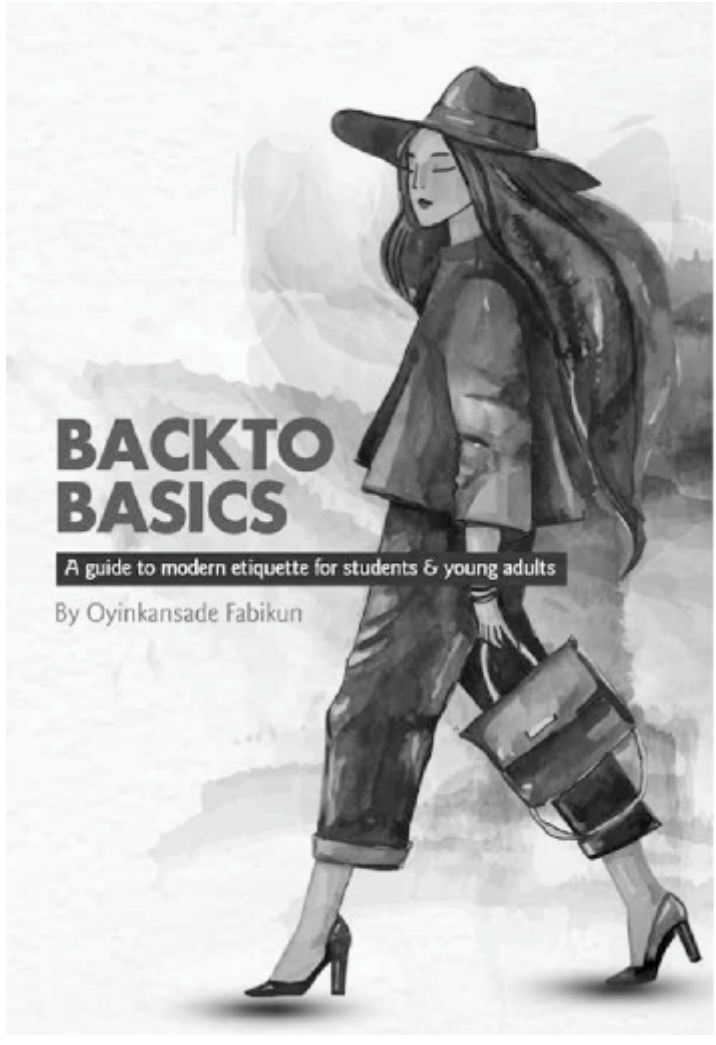

BACKTO
BASICS
A guide to modern etiquette for students & young adults
By Oyinkansade Fabikun

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INTRODUCTION

Etiquette is a set of rules observed by civilized and cultivated people in relations with other people and their environment.

Etiquette emphasizes on consideration for others, kindness and moral propriety.
The exhibition of this code is bound to improve your appeal to people you come across and leave a positive enduring impression on their minds.

As the name implies, ***Back to Basics*** is a manual that explains the nitty-gritty of displaying etiquette and good manners and observing deference.

It is especially written for teenagers and young adults who are at a formative and impressionable stage, to mould them into decent and respectable ladies and gentlemen.

It is necessary to revive the dying nature of courtesy and decorum which are rightly referred to as 'old-school' because they seem like practices of the past that can be dispensed with, particularly in this part of the world.

The necessary revival of these qualities begins with this book as the principles contained herein are bound to stand you out from a garden-variety crowd.

Emily Post, American etiquette guru said, **"Manners are a sensitive awareness of the feelings of others. If you have that awareness, you have good manners, no matter which fork you use."**

It is a hallmark of courtesy to consider the feelings of others in acting or reacting to them; this also involves the use of public amenities. Inconsiderate use of public facilities goes against the essence of etiquette, which is why basic civil laws are also discussed in this book.

Quotes on etiquette and politeness by distinguished persons are found throughout the following pages to drive home cogent points and also to serve as aide-memoires.

One of such quotes is this by Clarence Thomas: *"Good manners will open the doors that the best education cannot."*

It is possible to be literate without being cultivated; as a matter of fact, a vast majority of literates fall into this category.

Cultivation is what will stand you out, attract a double-take and open a door that was otherwise closed to ordinary literacy.

Chapter one

The Formalities of Salutation

To be ignorant of one's ignorance is the malady of the ignorant- Amos Branson Alcott

The prefatory gesture in the establishment of any relationship is a greeting.

It is therefore important to know the basics of exchanging pleasantries which form the basis of all relationships.

Manners of greeting vary from place to place and from people to people.

A simple 'Good morning' is perfectly acceptable to an Englishman while the same greeting without kneeling, curtseying or tilting the head to an African elder is somewhat rude.

In the same vein, many Western cultures are unaccustomed to prostrate-greeting and knee-greeting which are common gestures in many African cultures. The 'greeter', 'greeted' and the event are determinants of the formality or informality of a greeting.

Informal greeting

This is a casual exchange of pleasantries, mostly between friends and family members where an individual may observe cultural doctrines of curtseying, kneeling or prostrating to elders.

This form of greeting is also characterized by the

exchange of fist bumps, high-fives, knuckle-jams, hugs and Italian kisses among contemporaries.

The informal greeting is traditionally taught at home.

Formal greeting

This entails the strict guidelines for exchanging and acknowledging salutation in formal settings.

It is inappropriate to manifest informal greeting styles in formal situations.

For instance, you shouldn't kneel every morning to greet your boss at the office even if he/she is African; a polite 'Good Morning Sir/ Ma' will do.

When someone says 'How do you do' in greeting, the correct response is the question-'How do you do'
The proper order of introduction is to introduce the subordinate to the important, the gentleman to the lady and the younger to the older.
To introduce your dad and friend for example, you should say, 'Dad, I'll like you to meet Bianca, my friend'. Then you turn to Bianca and say, 'Bianca, meet my dad'.

It is rude not to introduce your friends who have no acquaintance of each other.

It is also important to remember people's names as they are introduced and inquire for their preferred appellation.

For example, if you are introduced to 'Chief Thomas Odion', you should ask what you may address him as. Some people prefer their titles while others prefer their names.

Avoid touching unfamiliar people in formal settings. Hugging and other intimate physical contacts are for friends and family.

Your manners are always under examination by committees little suspected, awarding or denying you very high prices when you least think of it- Ralph Waldo Emerson

The handshake

A handshake is the most widely acceptable formal gesture of greeting.

Some religions and customs however frown at unrelated opposite sexes having any form of physical contact, especially in public.

In this instance, a handshake will not be appreciated.

In a formal situation, the distinguished, the older and the lady have the prerogative of extending their hand first; in that order- you shouldn't extend your hand to a king or president simply because you're female.

In the event that they do not extend their hands for a handshake, a verbal greeting will have to suffice.

A formal handshake should:

- Be done with the right hand.
- Last between 3- 5 seconds.
- Be done while standing.
- Not be done with wet or moist palms.
- Not be done with dry palms either.
- Be done within 2.5 feet.
- Not be a very firm grip.
- Not be too loose either.
- Be done while smiling with a friendly expression.
- Be done with a maximum of 3 pumps.
- Be done while looking the other person in the eye.
- Involve web-locking of the two hands- the area between the thumb and index finger.

Manners are a sensitive awareness of the feelings of others. If you have that awareness, you have good manners, no matter which fork you use. - Emily Post



A handshake should involve web-locking of the two hands- the area between the thumb and index finger.

Meeting royalty

Meeting royalty is a dream that many have.
It is important that you know the rules and avoid awkwardness that comes from unpreparedness if you do meet one.

The decorum involved in greeting and interacting with royalties varies from culture to culture.

The Queen of England may shake your hand as a lady while an Emir may not.

By the book:
Never extend your hand first for a handshake; it is the royal's prerogative to initiate it.

If they do not, smile as you greet.

- It is not compulsory to curtsey to the Queen of England if you are not a citizen of the UK or a British Overseas Territory (this applies to the female folk). Gentlemen may bow slightly.
- Gentlemen should gallantly tilt their head while removing any headwear.
- Do not initiate or control the conversation, let the royal do that.
- The appropriate title for addressing the Queen of England is 'Your Majesty' at initial greeting. Subsequently, it is 'Ma'am'

then 'Your Majesty' in the final greeting or when the conversation is coming to a close.

- Whatever you do, do not touch royals.
- The appropriate title for Princes, Princesses, Dukes or Duchesses is 'His / Her / Your Royal Highness'.
- Acceptable titles for local royals and chiefs is ' Your Highness' or 'Your Royal Highness' for kings, queens or those with just as important royal positions.
- If you are the one doing the introductions, you should say 'Your Majesty, May I present to you Miss Beauty' or 'Your Majesty, I have the honour to present Mr. Handsome'

How to curtsey to the Queen

When curtseying to the Queen of England, stand with your feet together, then cross the left foot and place it just behind the right and genuflect slightly. You should make eye contact with her. This pose should last for a few seconds before you lift yourself up and place your legs together again.

Good manners are just a way of showing other people that we have respect for them. ~Bill Kelly



Cross the left foot and place it just behind the right and genuflect slightly

Meeting dignitaries

Similar rules should be observed when meeting dignitaries such as Presidents, Heads of state, Captain of industries and other high-ranking individuals.

Even though they do not have royal titles, the following should be observed:

- It is their discretion to extend their hand for a handshake.
- The President, Governor or First lady is called 'Your Excellency' or 'Mr. President' for the President.
- Stand when they enter and exit the venue and when they walk to or from the platform.
- A Senator is always referred to as a Senator, whether serving or past.



Knowledge test

Should you introduce a lady to a gentleman or a gentleman to a lady?



Did you know?

That the appropriate response to 'top of the morning' is 'and the rest of the day to yourself'?

Chapter two

Appearance & Presence

Keep up appearances whatever you do
- Charles Dickens

A person's appearance is important in creating an impression about them.

Remember, ***the way you dress is the way you will be addressed.***

In other words the kind of audience you receive is directly proportional to your choice of appearance.

If you want to be taken seriously and have an elegant appearance, gentlemen and ladies must take note of the following.

For the ladies

- A lady is to be modest in her appearance. A formal appearance requires that ladies be moderately covered.
- Avoid clothes that are too clingy or bogus or clothes that reveal the cleavage, belly and other sensitive body parts.
- When wearing pantyhose, keep in mind that opaque ones are for shorter clothes while sheer ones are for longer ones.
- Apply makeup to enhance your features but don't apply disproportionately or you may look like a clown.
- A lady should have on well-styled, modest hairdo.

- Ladies should use hair accessories to style and hold their hair, not common rubber bands.
- She should walk smartly without dragging her feet or bouncing her head.
- A lady shouldn't slouch.
- She shouldn't expose undergarments carelessly or in an attempt to display a fashion sense.
- A lady's choice of outfit should be dictated by the weather, occasion and time of day.
- Elegance is preferable to flamboyance.
- Walk in a straight line but don't strut.
- Always carry your handbag on your left arm to keep the right hand, which is also the hand used to shake hands and socialize, free.
- A lady may cross her legs at the ankles but not at the knees.
- Nail polishes are either on or off; chipped nail polish is not complimentary to a lady's appearance.
- Don't wear more than one colour of nail polish on your fingernails.
- A lady should not push her hips out when standing but should stand straight with her hands clasped in front of her.
- A lady must also avoid pushing out the back of her knees while standing; this pose is always unflattering.
- A lady must take note to wear long enough clothing so that her in-betweens are unseen

when she sits.

- A scarf may be discreetly spread over her knees to cover them up when she sits.

Contents of a Lady's Handbag

Every lady's handbag should contain seven categories of essential tools for hygienic, preservative and security purposes.

A lady's handbag should serve as a 'first aid container' which she can utilize in exigencies.

Hand Sanitizer/Moisturizer:

This is for hygienic and beauty purposes.

Washing the hands with soap and water is a better alternative to using sanitizers but when both are not immediately available, a sanitizer can suffice.
Hand creams keep the hands decently moist after they are washed and prevent them from coarseness which can make for awkward handshakes.

Breath Improving Substance:

These include breath fresheners, lozenges, and mint-flavoured sweets.

These come in handy when a toothbrush and toothpaste are not immediately available.

They should be used between 6-8 hours after brushing whether or not food or drink has been consumed.

They should especially be used after consuming strong spices and alcohol-containing drinks or food.

It is important to remember though that breath fresheners 'mask' smell while brushing with toothpaste removes it. Popping mints or fresheners is just a temporary attempt to forestall odour.

Absorbent material such as toilet paper, handkerchief:
These are essential equipment primarily used to dab the face or neck to remove tears, sweat and other body wastes. A lady should always have a mop-up in her possession.

Defensive Weapon Such as Pepper Spray:
It is important for ladies to have in their possession a defensive weapon seeing that they are very vulnerable to attacks and assaults.
It is equally important to know how best to use these weapons and how to hold them discreetly so as not to alert the attacker of your defence.

An Educative Tool Such as a Pen or Book:
Learning and reading are essential for a lady's social

relevance, intelligence and, inevitably, confidence.
It is therefore of social importance to have a book at hand or have a pen to note an unfamiliar word or phenomenon to check up later.

Beauty Bag:
This should contain lip gloss, face powder and other beauty-enhancing materials which are naturally needed for reapplication after a while.
Legal Tender Such As Money or a Debit Card:
The importance of money in desperate situations cannot be overemphasized.

Other contents should include portable first aid kit, needle and thread, safety pins, superglue, bobby pins, finger moisteners, sanitary towel and so on.

Courtesies cannot be borrowed like snow shovels; you must have some of your own.
~John Wanamaker

For gentlemen
Don't sag your trousers; gentlemen wear their trousers on their waist.
Don't pierce your body, or put on earrings.
Your only jewelleries should be your watch, handcuffs and tie pin (if you are wearing a tie).
Tattoo is a taboo for gentlemen.
For formal events, opt for formal suits and button up.

Knot your tie to standing perfection.
Polish your shoes.

Men acquire a particular quality by consistently acting in a particular way
- Aristotle.

Unlike the ladies, gentlemen should have at least 5 things in their possession. They are:

- Money.
- Breath freshener.
- Cologne.
- A handkerchief.
- A learning tool.

These should be in the possession of gentlemen for the same reasons stated above.
A handkerchief should be held by a gentleman to offer to a lady in the event that she needs one while a cologne makes for a better hug.

For both

- Avoid the use of swear words and slangs in civil conversation.
- Don't size up people to their faces.
- Walk into a room with a polite measure of confidence. There's a fine line between confidence and

haughtiness though, don't cross it.

- It's impolite to stare at others.
- Do not snap your fingers to get someone's attention.

When walking into/through a row of seats, edge in with your back to the platform or the front of the hall while your anterior should be toward the other seated attendees.

This is in order because edging in with your posterior to the seated guests will mean extending your lower back and derriere to other people's faces, which is rude. When getting into or out of a vehicle, it is proper to use the door closest to the building or sidewalk, not the one towards the road.

It is very becoming when a gentleman acts in preference to a lady.
A lady should act as independent as a situation or her attire permits and not take advantage of gentlemen.
Don't lie around in public places.
Don't chew on your fingernails in public.
A gentleman is required by nature to be energetic, able to perform basic tasks such as driving, golfing, changing tyres, electric bulbs, and other gentlemanly-demanding sport and skill.
He should also be brave enough to defend ladies when they are victims of violence from their violators.



Knowledge test

Should a lady cross her legs at the ankles or at the knees?



Did you know?

That when a lady wears a belt on her belly, she appears shorter than she actually is?

Chapter three

Characteristics of cultured ladies and gentlemen

"To educate a person in the mind but not in morals is to educate a menace to the society."
- Theodore Roosevelt

Another important criterion by which you will be addressed is the way you behave.

Even though etiquette demands that everyone should be treated with courtesy regardless of who they are, a display of rudeness may earn you a humiliating penalty sometimes.

For instance, if you queue-jump without due regard for others, you may be shown out of the premises for misconduct.

Here are some guidelines to observe so as to distinguish oneself as a lady or a gentleman.

- It is indecent to blow your nose in public. If you must, do it discreetly.
- Never spit anywhere outside the bathroom.
- You may point at objects but never at people.
- Never moisten your fingers with spit to flip a page or count money; use finger moisteners instead.
- It is impolite to queue jump, wait your turn.
- In emergency situations, take due permission from those at the front of the queue and the person in charge.
- It is very ethical to give up your seat for the elderly, invalid or vulnerable.
- Hold the door open for the next person behind

you if you see them approaching.

- Always knock on closed doors and wait for a response. If there's no response after fifteen seconds, knock again. If there's still no response after another 15 seconds, attempt the handle.
- Wait to be offered a seat before taking one.
- If your host seems to forget to offer you a seat, you should ask, 'May I have a seat please?'
- Never place your feet on your host's furniture.
- Settle your weight gradually into a chair, don't slump.
- Sit uprightly. Armrests could make you slouch.
- Always ensure that the soles of your shoes face the ground when you are seated.
- It's not always ladies first- The gentleman precedes the lady in ascending the stairs but the lady precedes the gentleman in descending.

Life be not so short but that there is always time for courtesy. ~Ralph Waldo Emerson

- Don't give compliments in company. If you do, you may compel others to insincerely corroborate.
- Gentlemen should remove hats or head wears at places of worship, in theatres and when greeting a lady.

- When greeting a lady, partial removal of head wears is acceptable.
- Simply say 'excuse me' when you want to go to the bathroom or attend to other temporary private needs, an explanation isn't necessary.
- Avoid swear words and vulgar languages in social settings.

An Englishman, even if he is alone, forms an orderly queue of one - George Mikes

- Don't make derogatory jokes about other people's faith, race or gender and don't laugh at such jokes.
- Never make a show of your extreme emotions in public.
- Ladies should climb into vehicles gracefully.

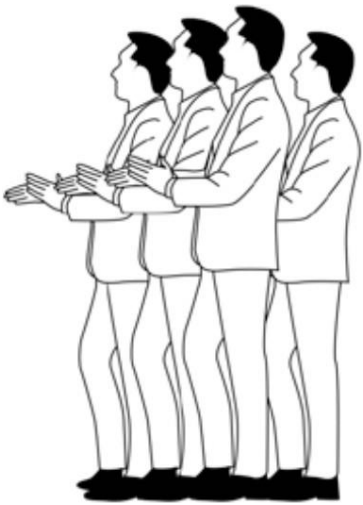
First, sit with your legs together, and then swing your legs still tightly held together into the vehicle.

- Avoid gum chewing while you are having a conversation with others. It's indecent to show the content you're chewing on.
- Never drink to your own toast or clap for your own recognition. Let others do that and revel in the moment gracefully while you clap at others' special moments too.
- Naturalness is preferable in a lady or

gentleman than affectation.

- Don't claim to have travelled to a place you haven't been to or fake an accent to impress others.
- A lady should not admire herself publicly in a mirror.
- When invited to an event, confirm your attendance or otherwise by corresponding to the RSVP, an acronym for Répondez s'il vous plait. This simply means 'the pleasure of a response is expected' in French.
- Gentlemen should not snap a lady's finger between theirs; she's not a homeboy.
- If you're invited by a friend to an event- a party or a sleepover, return the gesture when you also have an event.





Never drink to your own toast or clap for your own recognition

Magic Words

The magic phrases as they are called, are an essential part of the vocabulary of ladies and gentlemen and should be used regularly- Thank you, please, you're welcome, excuse me and I'm sorry/ I beg your pardon.

Thank you: When given a compliment, say 'thank you'. When you're given anything at all, say 'thank you'.

Please: Use this to make a polite request. Always ask with a 'please' and receive with a 'thank you'. 'May I' could also be used to make a polite request.

You're welcome: You should say this to acknowledge a 'thank you'. Another alternative is 'It's my pleasure'.

Excuse me: You should use this to politely call for someone's attention or to politely take your leave from a gathering.

I'm sorry/ I beg your pardon: This is said to apologise for a wrongdoing.

Other polite expressions are:
'Pardon me' to politely ask someone to repeat what he/ she said because you didn't hear them.

Also, if a neighbour sneezes, you should say 'bless you'

or ‘gesundheit’.

How to respond to embarrassing situations

We are bound to make mistakes because we are humans; besides, other people’s mistakes may bring us some level of embarrassment.

It is important we take the high road at such instances. We sometimes ask questions or pay ‘compliments’ out of good intentions but this does not mean that we do not embarrass others while at it- good intentions sometimes produce bad outcomes.

Effective remedies include:

1. Apologise for the gaffe. A faux pas can be graciously corrected by apologizing if one is in the wrong.
2. Make a light humour of it (if you can)
3. Make restitution if this is possible.
4. Excuse yourself where applicable.
5. Forget it and act normally.



Knowledge test

What is the correct response to ‘Thank you’?



Did you know?

That Nelson Mandela of South Africa is the first non-relative to call the Queen of England by her first name?

Chapter four

Impeccable Table manners

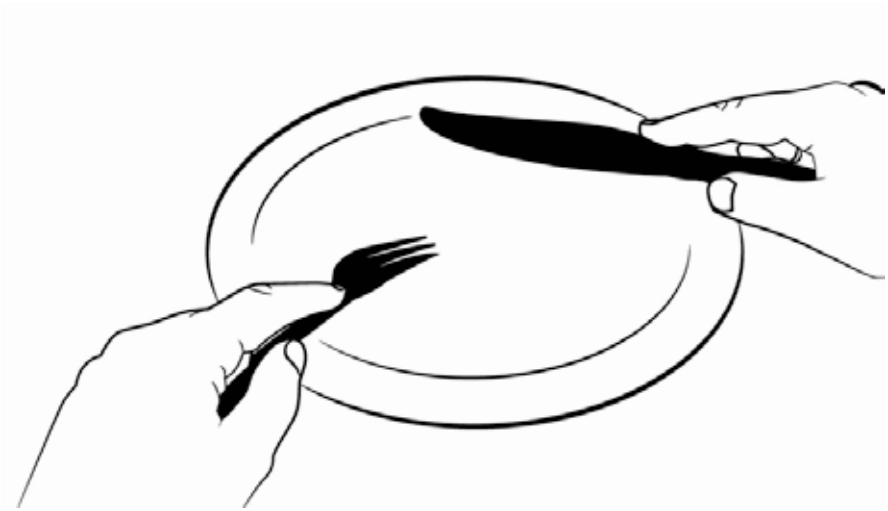
I eat my peas with honey;
I've done it all my life.
They do taste kind of funny,
But it keeps them on the knife
- Anonymous

The art of flawless dining is an indispensable skill when it comes to important public events and formal dinners. Ignorance should not be an excuse to decline such invitations. Below are points to memorize as you approach a set table.

- Enter your dinner chair from the left and exit from the right hand side.
- Gentlemen should help ladies to their left get seated and remember to stand when ladies leave and return to the table. A half stand is a polite enough gesture.
- Table napkins should be spread across your lap to protect clothing from possible spills and stains as you eat and drink but it is not an excuse to dine with negligence.
- Wait till everyone is served before you begin to eat. Then set or follow a convenient pace so that you are not the only one still eating long after others have finished nor are you the first to finish while others are halfway through their meal.
- Use the cutleries provided to eat.
- You should eat to your left and drink to your right in the event that the table is overburdened with dining utensils.
- Always say thank you when you are served something- even a glass of water.
- Do not fill a glass or cup to the brim.

- Use a teacup and saucer to take tea, not a mug.
- The teaspoon is used to stir the tea but never to taste it. After stirring, noiselessly place the teaspoon on the saucer; don't leave it in the cup.
- Ensure that the handle of the teacup is in a 3'o clock position when drinking. The teacup is held on the right hand while the saucer is held on the left. The saucer may not be lifted from the table if you are seated but should be lifted if you stand.
- For formal meals, use utensils arranged outward first, those arranged middle second and those exactly beside the plate last. In other words, let the last be the first and vice versa.
- When dining with fork and knife, hold the knife in your right and the fork in your left with the tines facing downward. Use the fork to dig and hold food as the knife cuts through, then lift the forked food (with the tines still pointing downwards) into your mouth whilst the knife remains in the right hand, on the plate.
- If you drop the knife with the intent of using only the fork to eat, the fork should be transferred to the right hand and not remain on the left. An exception applies to the left-handed.
- If the fork is the sole utensil, then the tines are turned upward when eating. A simple rule of thumb is- the fork bows before the knife.

- The fork is held at the handle between your index finger and thumb. If this is done correctly, the fork should rest a bit on the side of your middle finger when it is the sole eating instrument.
- The fork and knife are not to be directed upwards but downwards when pausing for conversation.
- To take a break in conversation, place the fork and knife at four o' clock and eight o' clock respectively. This shows you are just pausing but not done eating.
- Don't brandish cutleries while eating- to demonstrate or emphasize a point,



The fork is held on the left while the knife is held on the right

- Don't add salt or pepper to food before tasting it- it is disrespectful to the host.
- Never blow hot food; wait till the temperature is cool enough before you eat.
- Do not rest your elbows or arms on the table while eating.
- Never stir the entire plate before you begin to eat; stir a little before taking a mouthful.
- Don't go to the food, bring the food to yourself.

There is a difference between dining and eating. Dining is an art- Yuan Mei

- If bread and butter is served, use the table knife or your butter knife to take some butter for your plate and butter your bread from the slab of butter on your plate. This you should do to avoid crumbs in the table butter everyone is taking from.
- Don't butter your bread directly from the butter served for everyone. Don't also butter an entire slice or piece of bread at once, except it is a toast. Instead, break a mouthful of bread and butter it from the slab of butter on your plate.
- Do not bite into bread or cut with a knife; rather tear off a decent mouthful with your hands.

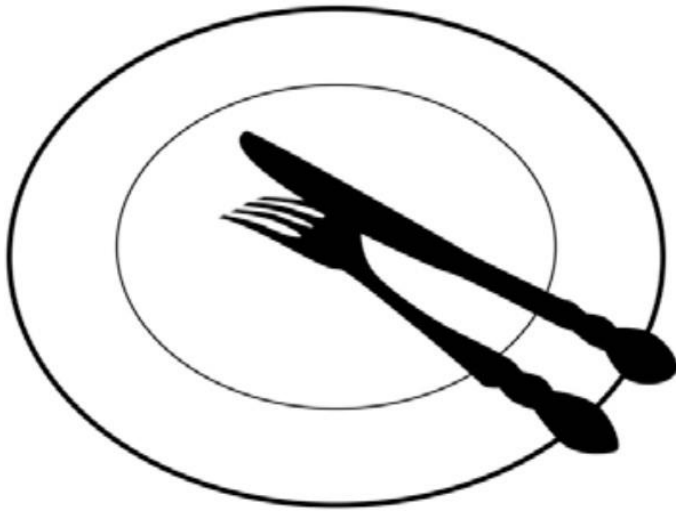
- Don't chew noisily or with your mouth open.
- Always chew and swallow all the food in your mouth before taking in more food or drink.
- When taking soup, scoop with the spoon away from you rather than toward you.
- Dab your lips gently with the napkin on your thighs before raising a glass or mug to your mouth to avoid smearing the glass or china with lipstick or food particles.
- Never remove food particle from your mouth in the sight of others. If you choke on a bone or other strange material, discreetly expel the stuff from your mouth.
- If your cutlery falls to the ground, politely request for another one; don't use the napkin to wipe it.
- Never say 'meat', say 'beef'.
- Always pass the salt along with the pepper irrespective of which was requested for.
- Don't bend over to get something you need. Rather, politely ask for the item from the person nearest to it.
- When passing an item on the table, pass it from left to right and place it in front of the diner; don't do it hand to hand.
- If there are lots of diners present and you need to ask someone to pass you an item, call them and politely ask for it.
- It is considered very rude to take food from

your neighbour's plate in a formal dining setting.

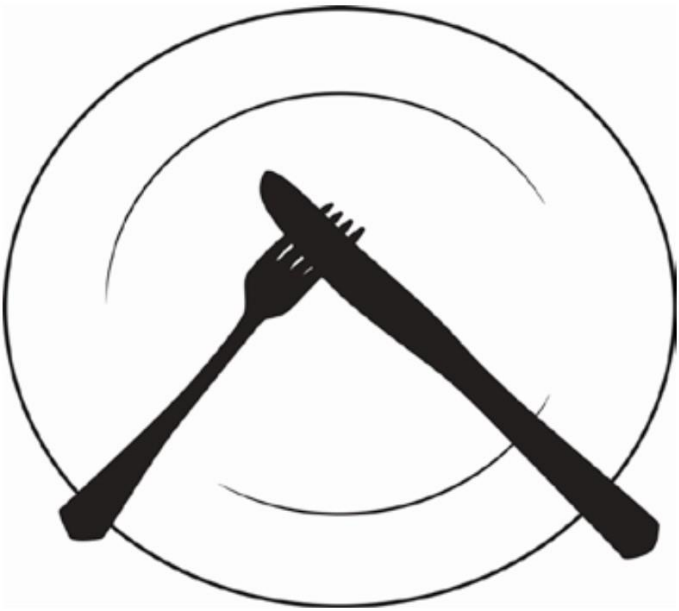
- If you must leave the table temporarily during a meal, simply say 'Excuse me', you do not have to give details of your leave.
- Do not use a toothpick or floss in the presence of others.
- Don't speak while your mouth is full.
- Always chew with your mouth closed.
- Don't take the last portion of any food item, be it a sandwich, a pie or a piece of chicken.
- If desert is served in a bowl, place the spoon on the plate when you are done eating, don't leave it inside the bowl.
- Don't leave a very clean plate after dining, neither should you waste food. Remain about a spoon full or two in the plate.
- When you've finished eating, place your fork and knife at a five o'clock position on the plate with the tines of the fork facing down and the blades of the knife facing in. This signals to the waiter or host that you are done eating and are ready to have the dishes cleared.

Good manners: The noise you don't make when you're eating soup- Bennett Cerf

- It is unnecessary to refold the napkin after the meal; place it loosely on either side of your plate.



When you've finished eating, place your fork and knife at a five o'clock position on the plate with the tines of the fork facing down and the blades of the knife facing in



To take a break in conversation, place the fork and knife at eight o'clock and four o'clock respectively

How to eat spaghetti

Spaghetti is an Italian food typically eaten with beef sauce and garnished vegetables.

It should be served in a semi-hollow dishware.

A few strands are lifted and twirled around a fork until the entire lengths are neatly rolled around the fork.

The edge of the bowl is used as a support to twirl the spaghetti strands around the fork.

Some people use a spoon to twirl the threads around the fork but this is loose table manners.

Don’t slurp the spaghetti.

Never cut the spaghetti strands.



Twirl the spaghetti strands around the fork

How to use chopsticks

Chopsticks are Asian eating utensils mainly used to eat rice and noodles in many parts of Asia.

There are two of them:
one is held between the ring finger and the thumb such that it is lying on the side of the ring finger while the other one is held between the index finger and the thumb and lies on the side of the middle finger.

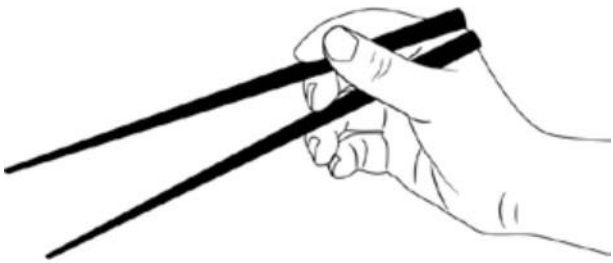
If they are held correctly, the middle finger should be between the two chopsticks.

When they are in use, the thumb, index finger and middle finger move and hold the chopsticks.

The ring finger and the little finger are largely inactive. The lower chopstick is stationary while the upper chopstick is mobile when picking food.

Food is held between the chopsticks.

Don't use the chopstick to stab the food.



The middle finger should be between the two chopsticks



Knowledge test

Should you pass an item on the table from right to left or from left to right?



Did you know?

That wearing a black tie (as a gentleman) is a prerequisite for dining with Queen Elizabeth?

Chapter five

E-etiquette

I'm making a list
I'm making a list of things I must say
For politeness,
And goodness and kindness and gentleness
Sweetness and rightness:
Hello
Pardon me
How are you?
Excuse me
Bless you
May I?
Thank you
Goodbye
If you know some I forgot,
Please stick them in your eye!
-Shel Silverstein

We seem to limit the practice of good manners to dining tables and physical encounters but the rules of decent interaction still stand, whether in the physical or over the internet.

The internet should not be a mask we hide behind so we can throw insults at others.

Take note of the following guidelines in your interaction over the internet or on your mobile device so you do not come across as boorish.

Swear Words: If you can't speak it, don't write it on your status.
There is a small voice in everyone that reads out your status so don't write or type what you cannot say with your mouth.
Your vocabulary is beyond verbal communication.

Abbreviation: Abbreviation or shorthand is not bad in itself when used exceptionally but a situation is created when good English is thrown out the window and replaced with shorthand or abbreviations, even in speaking.

English words are being abbreviated (including words that have no need for this) at such a fast pace it's hard to keep up.

A good reason to avoid shorthand is that it spoils your English.
Sometimes, you sincerely forget the spelling of words as simple as 'this' because you are too used to abbreviations.
If you must use short hand, use it sparingly and in a decipherable context.
Make good English a standard in writing, speaking or typing.

Suggestive pictures, updates and statuses: When updating your social media with pictures from a party or hangout, keep it moderate.
Keep in mind that you can be cool without being too showy.

Late Pings: Just as it is unethical to place late night calls for reasons besides emergencies, late night chatty messages especially to a contact with whom you aren't overly familiar can be unwelcoming.
The exception is when the conversation is consensual though.
It's just kind of unusual to ping someone by 2am in the morning 'just to say hello'.

Graphic Videos/Links: If you must advertise a graphic link, please be considerate enough to warn potential viewers.
Responsible advert calls for this.

Tagging: When posting pictures which you are uncertain about on Facebook, it is appropriate to ask the consent of others before tagging them.

Not everyone likes to go on Facebook to find strange pictures on their wall.

If you are certain that this picture is inoffensive and your friends won't mind you tagging them, then that's fine.

I seek to constantly improve my manners and graces, for they are the sugar to which all are attracted - Og Mandino.

Ringing devices: It is appropriate to turn devices to the silent mode during religious services or during classes, at the library or at meetings.

You can always return a missed call or respond to a message later.
If the call is important, you may excuse yourself to attend to it but never answer a call in a gathering, it is distracting.

Communicative Gaffes to Avoid
If a person comes in while you are conversing, it's handsome to repeat what was said before- George Washington

Never interrupt while someone else is speaking.
Speak carefully, pronounce your words correctly and don't slur.
When a residential landline rings, answer it thus: "Hello good morning, Clark's residence. How may I help you?"
If you are the caller, greet, introduce yourself and state why you're calling.
Always be tactful- someone who appears to have a bigger stature should not be called 'fat'.
Don't gossip, remember, 'What Suzie says of Sally says more of Suzie than of Sally'.
Speak the truth always, avoid mistruths and half-truths.
Try to pronounce other people's names properly.
Maintain an even tone while speaking, avoid raising your voice but be audible.
Don't speak with a shrill voice.
Avoid the 3 offenses of speaking- speaking too much, too fast and too loud.



Knowledge test

Should you turn your phone to the silent mode during classes and meetings or should you leave it ringing loudly?



Did you know?

That you should always read the manual of a new gadget or device even if you already know how to operate it?

Chapter six

Corpus juris civilis
(Body of the Civil Law)

For a man by nothing is so well betrayed as by his manners- Edmund Spencer

I'm sure you've heard the adage, 'when you are in Rome, do as the Romans do'.
This is because everyone must conform to the law or face the consequences that come with disregard for it. More than anything, a person of high moral compass should not be caught breaking the law, not because of the consequences but out of self-respect and integrity.

What are the laws to be obeyed?
We are familiar with the common ones- it's a crime to kill, to steal or abet criminals, but what other seemingly unimportant legislations do we ignore that can increase our moral and social appeal?

- Stop at red. When you are driving, you should stop when the traffic light shows red and go at green.
- Stop at the zebra crossing to allow pedestrians walk when the traffic light or traffic warden signifies so.
- Do not litter your surroundings or throw thrash out of the car window. You may endanger other road users, contribute to flooding and disfigure the environment.
- Do not offer bribe to civil servants or any other persons to secure favours. You may however tip them. The difference between bribing and tipping is bribing is done to evade/escape the consequence of a fault or wrongdoing with the

person on the wrong side of the law or the officer in charge initiating it while a tip is a gracious gesture of appreciation for impressive execution of duty based on the giver's discretion without the officer initiating it.

- Do not walk on the grass when there's a sidewalk or pathway available for this.
- Report crime cases to the nearest police station.
- Take the bridge rather than dash across the street or highway.
- If there's no bridge in sight, look carefully to the left, to the right and to the left again before crossing the road.
- Do not deface or destroy public property.
- Ensure that vehicle particulars are accurate, complete and up-to-date before driving.
- Always take your driver's license along with you when driving.
- Know your rights and be guided by them.
- Know what public symbols and signs stand for.



Use the trash containers

- Don't ease yourself in public.
- Rather than walking side by side with moving vehicles, walk against traffic. It is safer.
- Gentlemen should walk between a lady and moving vehicles by the sidewalk so that they act as a guard, protecting her. Adults should do same for children.
- When driving, allow ambulances and official government vehicles to go ahead or overtake due to the urgency of their jobs.
- Always horn before overtaking.
- Occupants in a moving vehicle must always fasten their seatbelts, particularly the driver and the occupant in the passenger seat.
- Activate a child lock in the back seat if children are in the car and place the 'Baby/child on board' notice sign on your vehicle.
- Children should not be seated at the passenger side of a vehicle but at the backseat.
- If you take your dog for a walk, ensure you carry along some toilet paper and plastic bag to clean up after them in case they defecate.
- If you must take a bike, ensure you wear a head helmet; ladies should put on trousers.

Know your rights

It is very important to know your rights; otherwise your ignorance may cost you.

The constitution of the Federal Republic of Nigeria,



Put on a helmet and trousers when riding a bike

under Chapter IV enumerates the following as fundamental human rights:

- Right to life.
- Right to dignity of human person.
- Right to personal liberty.
- Right to fair hearing.
- Right to private and family life.
- Right to freedom of thought, conscience and religion.
- Right to freedom of expression and the press.
- Right to peaceful assembly and association.
- Right to freedom of movement.
- Right to freedom from discrimination on the grounds of ethnic group, place of origin, circumstance of birth, sex, religion or political opinion.



Knowledge test

Which of the following can a lawful citizen do? Bribe, tip?



Did you know?

That it is wrong to tip in Japan? It is considered offensive

Chapter seven

Hygiene, Health & Safety

Knowing is not enough, we must apply, willing is not enough, we must do. -Johann Wolfgang von Goethe

Personal hygiene is the total cleanliness of the body. It is important that we take adequate measures to clean our bodies and avoid emitting odours as this can be embarrassing to us and uncomfortable to our neighbours.

The following are essential to good personal hygiene.

- Take a bath at least twice a day and use a good anti-per spirant or deodorant afterwards.
- Brush your teeth at least twice in a day most importantly at morning, at night and after a spicy meal.
- Brushing the teeth prevents plaque and inevitably, mouth odour from building in the mouth and gives a fresh breath.
- Use a suitable mouthwash after brushing.
- Use a hand sanitizer after handshakes.
- Trim nails to a decent length and ensure they are clean at all times.
- Shave hair growing in certain areas, i.e. ears, nose, under arms and so on.
- Don't repeat clothes consecutively, especially in hot weathers.
- Ladies with hairy legs should shave.
- Wash your hair weekly or every other week to avoid hair odour.
- Always wash hands before handling food or snacks; you may keep a hand sanitizer nearby

for the same purpose.

- Floss your teeth at night or after meals.
- If you feel your mouth going stale, (this could begin to occur after about 7 hours of freshening it) pop a mint-flavoured sweet, gum or lozenge to freshen your breath.
- Sneeze or cough away from others and always cover your mouth with your left hand. The right hand should not be used since it is for shaking hands.

Bathroom Etiquettes

Always leave the bathroom as neat as or neater than you met it. If the bathroom is too dirty, then don't use it at all.

Gentlemen should always keep the toilet seat down when a lady is in the house.
Disinfect the toilet bowl if you can and make it denser by lining the bowl with toilet paper so the water doesn't spatter on you as you use it.

It is advisable to squat rather than sit on a public toilet for obvious reasons.
Never take a newspaper or magazine into the bathroom, it may get contaminated.

Don't start a conversation while you're in the process of easing yourself; wait till you're done.

When flushing a public toilet, use a piece of toilet paper to push the flush handle/ button. If there's no toilet paper, then you may push with your elbow.
If you smear the toilet bowl while using it, use the brush to clean it.

Always flush the toilet after use. If the flush isn't working, call the attention of the bathroom attendant and direct the person after you to another bathroom. Never leave your waste for anyone to behold.

Always look into the bowl after flushing to ensure everything is gone. If there are some remnants, wait for the tank to refill and flush again.

Always flush with the lid. The whirl of the water stirs up microscopic particles of waste which may end up on you if the lid is uncovered.

Wipe any visible droplets of water or waste off the seat. Use an air freshener after you're done if it's available. Never leave evidence of your presence behind.



Trim nails to a decent length

HEALTH & BEAUTY

Good manners are made up of petty sacrifices- Ralph Waldo Emerson

Good health is a vital prerequisite for beauty; more attention should be paid to the beauty that comes with healthy practices than that which comes from superficial efforts.

Beauty does not necessarily mean starving yourself to shed some pounds or other ridiculous things done to fit into the narrow definition of beauty.

Be pretty if you can, be witty if you must, but be gracious if it kills you- Elsie de Wolfe

Important tips for 'healthy beauty' include:

- Drink at least, a glass of water first thing in the morning, thirty minutes before meals and an hour afterwards- this aids digestion, keeps skin glowing and significantly improves the circulation of blood which in turn leads to other numerous health benefits.
- Exercise regularly- at least thirty minutes a day, five days a week emphasizing particularly on aerobics (jogging, swimming, and cycling). They have tremendous advantages in heart,

lung and skin health.

- Include fruits and vegetables in at least a third of daily meals. Favour especially raw vegetables and greens such as carrots, cucumber, almonds, cabbage, lettuce, spring onions etc. What you eat have a habit of reflecting on your skin and telling on the scale.
- It's been said that it is unsafe to drink while driving; well it is unhealthy to drink (even water) while eating too, so to speak. As noted earlier, it is best to drink a while before or after eating, particularly cold drinks. Drinking while eating causes discomfort, flatulence and a protruding waistline in the long run which is a threat to good health.
- Taking cold drinks while or immediately after eating is not healthy. It does more harm when the food contains hydrogenated fats and oils which congeal once mixed with cold drinks and slows down the digestion process.
- If you can help it, take lukewarm water after eating oily food rather than cold drinks.
- Sleep for a minimum of 7 hours and a maximum of 8 hours every night.
- Always apply sunscreen, even when the sun is not in sight.

General Safety Tips

- Switch off electrical appliances when they are not in use.
- Put off the switch before plugging or unplugging a device.
- Always wear rubber soled shoes when operating plugged in electrical devices.
- Do not operate a switch or circuit barefooted, on a wet floor or when it's raining.
- In the event that someone experiences an electric shock, don't touch him or her. Rather, turn off the source of the electricity if possible and if not, use any stuff made of wood or cardboard to disconnect your friend from the source; don't touch with bare hands, metal, iron or other conductors of electricity as the current may be passed on to you.
- When making phone calls, wait till the recipient has answered the phone before bringing the receiver close to your ear.
- Always cover food when microwaving.
- Never use stainless steel or aluminium in the microwave. Use only 'microwave safe' dishes.
- Pierce sausages, hot dogs, potatoes and similar foods to keep them from exploding in the microwave.
- Always cover food, fruits and drinks while they are in the fridge or freezer.

How to use a fire extinguisher

One of the most important things to keep in mind when it comes to putting out fires is that there are different kinds of fire extinguishers for different types of fires.

According to some system of classification, there are five kinds of fires.

Class A: Small fires that burn materials like cloth, wood, paper or plastic.
Class B: Fires that burn flammable liquids and gases.
Class C: Fires caused by electricity
Class d: Fires that burn metals.
Class K: Fires that arise from oil and grease.

Class ABCK represents the most common types of fires, especially domestic fires.
Fire extinguishers are labelled accordingly so that the right kind of extinguisher is used for the fire.
Fire extinguishers labelled **ABC** can be used for any of the fires in this category.
Three things should be noted when you want to put out a fire with an extinguisher:
You must be taller than the fire. Fire extinguishers can only put out small fires, not large ones.
The fire extinguisher should be applicable to the fire.
It must be pressurized. If the gauge points at the green

mark, the fire extinguisher is pressurized.
Your back must be toward an exit in the event that the fire surges.

- In the event of a kitchen fire, close doors and close the pot with a metal lid- a glass lid will break. If the fire doesn't still go out, pour baking soda on the fire. If the fire persists and you do not know how to operate a fire extinguisher, get out and call for fire service.
- Note- don't pour water in an attempt to quench the fire (water is not a good solution for grease fires)
- Generally, determine the cause and source of fire before attempting to quench it as fire extinguishing depends on the causative agent.

Fire extinguishers must be strategically placed in fire-prone areas like the kitchen and electrical control room or panel.

The acronym **PASS** will help when putting out fires.
P- Pull the pin.
A-Aim for the base of the fire; ensure the nozzle is pointed to the base and not the head of the flames.
S- Squeeze the trigger until the content is released.
S- Sweep from side to side while still aiming for the base; don't concentrate on only a spot.

Safety tips for ladies

- If you are walking alone at night, take familiar routes.
- Be very conscious of your surroundings.
- Ensure your phone is fully charged.
- Always take a bottle of pepper spray or a defensive weapon.
- If you are attacked, scream very loudly.
- Learn a few taekwondo moves.



Knowledge test

Should you disconnect a friend who is experiencing electrical shock from the source of the electricity with your bare hands or with a wooden pole?



Did you know?

That sodium bicarbonate (baking soda) is an effective deodorant when made as a paste with water?

Thank you for reading!

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